Placement Committee

COVER LETTER GUIDELINES

The purpose of a cover letter is to quickly summarize why you are applying to an organization or for a particular position, and what skills and knowledge you bring that make you the most suitable candidate for that position.

DO’S AND DON’TS

Do’s

- Always customize your letter for each application.
- Keep it concise - one page is ideal.
- Explain why you’re interested in the role and how it aligns with your skills and goals.
- Quantify your achievements and use action verbs.
- Have a strong opening statement that makes clear why you want the job and what you bring to the table.

Don’ts

- Don’t use generic or cliché phrases.
- Avoid repeating your résumé word-for-word.
- Don’t focus too much on what you want; emphasize what you can offer the company.
- Don’t use overly formal or robotic language; keep it professional yet engaging.

PWSA FORMAT

The **PWSA format** is a structured approach to writing a cover letter that connects past experience to future opportunities. It involves:

- **Past experiences** (relevant roles/projects)
- **Work done** (specific contributions and achievements)
- **Skills learned** (technical and soft skills gained)
- **Application to the new role** (how these experiences and skills make you a strong fit)

This format ensures a clear, logical flow that effectively demonstrates your qualifications and enthusiasm for the position.

PWSA FORMAT

Past Experiences: Begin by briefly mentioning relevant past roles, internships, or projects. Focus on positions that align with the job you're applying for.

Example: You could reference a leadership position in a student organization, a research project, an internship, or freelance work.

Work Done: Highlight key contributions, projects, or responsibilities in those roles. Use specific examples and quantify achievements where possible.

Example: Instead of saying you "assisted with tasks," say, "Coordinated a team project, streamlined a process, or developed a solution that improved efficiency."

PWSA FORMAT

Skills Learned: Emphasize the technical, analytical, or soft skills gained from your experiences. Showcase how these skills make you a strong candidate.

Example: You might mention strengthening problem-solving abilities, improving communication skills, learning a new software, or developing research and analytical skills.

Application to New Role: Connect your past experience and skills to the current job. Explain why you're a good fit and how you can add value to the company.

Example: “My ability to adapt quickly and collaborate effectively makes me well-suited for this position, where I can contribute to team success and take on new challenges.”

TIPS

- Make sure your cover letter fits onto **one page**, has consistent margins and formatting, and has a readable font that is between **10-12 pts**.
- Research the **company’s website and job description** to match your tone to their culture.
- Keep paragraphs short and impactful.
- While your résumé is meant to be a look back at your experience and where you’ve been, **the cover letter should focus on the future and what you want to do**.
- Emphasize your personal value by showcasing **unique skills and experiences** that align with the **company's needs and contribute to its success**.

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

Upenn Resources
Harvard Resource
MIT Resource

← For personalised cover letter feedback and improvements, email us or reach out via the Placecom Chatroom to schedule office hours